Lesson 24: Subject-Verb Agreement

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 10 Subject-Verb Agreement.

In this lesson

In English, a subject and its verb must match: a singular subject takes a singular verb, and a plural subject takes a plural verb. You learn four strategies and ten rules for choosing the correct verb, and practise them in texts about winter fun in Chicago. Agreement errors are easy for a reader to notice, so checking them is an important editing step.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Find the subject of a sentence, even when a prepositional phrase comes before the verb.
- Turn a complicated subject into a pronoun (he, she, it or they) to choose the verb.
- Apply the ten rules of subject-verb agreement.
- Find and correct agreement errors in a paragraph.
- Write paragraphs with correct subject-verb agreement.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
subject-verb agreement	the subject and its verb match: singular with singular, plural with plural	Most students love snow days.
compound subject	two or more subjects joined by "and"	A wool scarf and a pair of earmuffs protect us from the biting cold.
indefinite pronoun	a pronoun that does not name a particular person or thing: everyone, nobody, each of …	Each of our professors allows a few extra minutes.
collective noun	a noun for a group: family, class, team, crowd, committee, jury, choir, audience	Our team always works hard.
gerund / infinitive	verb + -ing used as a noun / to + base verb	Reading is my main activity on a snow day.
prepositional phrase	a preposition + a noun or pronoun: in the room, from him	A reliable car with good tires is essential on snowy days.
non-count noun	a noun with no plural form: air, knowledge, milk, news	Cold air is fresh and crisp on a winter morning.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
committee (n)	a group of people selected to work on a special task	a collective noun (Rule 6)
indispensable (adj)	absolutely necessary, essential	Scissors are indispensable for a snow-day art project.
empowering (adj) / assurance (n)	feeling powerful / the feeling of being sure	It is empowering to have the assurance that you are using the language correctly.
delight (v)	enjoy	Children delight in light gazing in the Lincoln Park Zoo.

Rules and explanations

Strategies

1. Look back at the subject before you choose the verb. Highlight the subject if necessary.
2. When a subject looks complicated, turn it into a pronoun: "a few snow days" → they (there **are** a few snow days); "everyone" → he or she (everyone **has** a day off); "the extra homework, like small projects" → it (the extra homework **keeps** the students busy).
3. Learn the ten rules below. They describe formal, standard English, which is sometimes different from informal speech: "None of my classmates enjoys driving in snow." (formal) / "None of my classmates enjoy ..." (informal)
4. Practise, and be conscious of your verbs.

Ten common rules

Rule 1. A singular subject takes the singular form of the verb; a plural subject takes the plural form. "We like outdoors, and our puppy loves outdoors, too."

Rule 2. A compound subject is "they": use the plural verb. "Both a jumper cable and a blanket are necessary to keep in the car."

Rule 3. With "or", "either ... or" and "neither ... nor", the verb agrees with the part after "or" or "nor".

- Either a blanket or warm clothes **keep** us warm. / Either warm clothes or a blanket **keeps** us warm.
- Sometimes neither talkative passengers nor loud music **is** able to keep the tired driver awake.

Rule 4. Many indefinite pronouns are singular: everybody, everyone, everything, somebody, someone, something, nobody, no one, nothing, either of, neither of, one of, each of, none of. "Neither of my two courses counts attendance as part of the grade." / "Last week, none of the students was late."

Rule 5. With "some", "all" or "most", look at the noun after it: a singular (or non-count) noun takes a singular verb; a plural noun takes a plural verb. "Some of the students do not have classes early in the morning." / "Some of the snow has melted."

Rule 6. A collective noun that acts as one unit is "it" (singular verb); when it focuses on the individual members, it is "they" (plural verb). "Our team always works hard." / "When the game was canceled due to snow, the team were not disappointed." If you are not sure, add "members": "Our team members ... work hard."

Rule 7. A gerund (verb + -ing used as a noun) or an infinitive (to + base verb) as the subject takes a singular verb. "Finding a parking spot close to my classroom building is almost impossible." / "To secure a good parking space on campus has been my struggle this semester." But two gerunds joined by "and" are a compound subject (Rule 2): "Postponing my homework till next week and dreaming of another snow day make me feel guilty but happy."

Rule 8. In a "there + be" sentence, the verb agrees with the noun after "be". "There are many parking spaces on campus." / "...when there is an important exam starting within ten minutes."

Rule 9. Some nouns are always singular, even with a final "s", and some are always plural.

Always singular	Always plural
non-count nouns: air, knowledge, milk, news, politics	clothes: clothes, jeans, pajamas, pants, shorts
school subjects: linguistics, mathematics, physics	groups: people, police
countries: the Netherlands, the Philippines, the United States	tools: glasses, pliers, scissors

"Scissors are indispensable for a snow-day art project." But: "A pair of scissors is indispensable." (Rule 10)

Rule 10. When a prepositional phrase comes between the subject and the verb, cross it out to find the subject. The subject and the verb do not change. (Here the phrases are in square brackets.) "A car dealership [on Golf Road] [near Harper campus] installs snow tires for customers." / "Many international students [from warm countries] often find Chicago winter extremely long and cold."

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - The Arabic words for "news" and "information" are plural, but in English these nouns are non-count and take a singular verb: "The news about the Lightscape usually appears in the social media", not "The news ... appear". Never write "informations".

Practice

1. Exercise 1 (Rules 1-3). Choose the correct verb. Example: Many people (has, have) suggested ways to have fun in Chicago winter. → have

1. One choice (is, are) to go ice-skating in the McCormick Tribune Plaza.
2. The place (welcomes, welcome) over 100,000 skaters annually.
3. Neither your own skates nor an admission fee (is, are) needed.
4. People (is, are) able to rent skates on site.
5. Families and friends always (has, have) a good time there.

6. Either a whole day in the skating rink or just a few hours (adds, add) fun to a cold day in Chicago.

2. Exercise 2 (Rules 4-5). Choose the correct verb. Example: One of the most popular parks for fun (is, are) the Millennium Park in Chicago. → is

1. Anyone (is, are) able to find fun things to do in the Millennium Park in Chicago, even in winter.
2. Every visitor (likes, like) to have his or her photos taken in front of the Cloud Gate, also called the Bean.
3. While each concert (draws, draw) thousands of visitors in summer, the snow-dusted Bean (is, are) a unique sight in this winter wonderland.
4. One of the reasons (is, are) that the Bean (reflects, reflect) the buildings as well as the people around it and from far away.
5. All these buildings and people (ends, end) up in the photos!

3. Exercise 3 (Rules 6-8). Write the correct verb in each blank. The first one is an example.

1. For families with children, the Lincoln Park Zoolights is (is, are) another attraction.
2. This annual event _____ (runs, run) around the holiday season, and there _____ (is, are) one million lights.
3. There _____ (is, are) hundreds of larger-than-life displays, including 3D displays.
4. When there _____ (is, are) snow, the scene _____ (seem, seems) more magical with all the twinkling lights.
5. Gift shopping _____ (offers, offer) additional fun to select holiday presents.
6. The entire family _____ (is, are) welcome.
7. To spend an unforgettable night there _____ (is, are) one of the highlights of family fun in the holiday season.

4. Exercise 4 (Rule 9). Write the correct verb in each blank. The first one is an example.

1. If you crave (craves, crave) for more holiday lights, another place to visit is (is, are) the Chicago Botanic Garden Lightscape.
2. The news about the Lightscape usually _____ (appears, appear) in the social media months ahead of time.
3. The Lightscape _____ (starts, start) in mid-December and _____ (ends, end) in early January every year.
4. Warm clothes _____ (is, are) needed because everything _____ (is, are) outdoors.
5. Boots _____ (is, are) absolutely necessary.
6. Visitors _____ (enjoys, enjoy) themselves in the surrounding of thousands of lights as they _____ (walks, walk) through the Cathedral of Light and _____ (listens, listen) to choir of singing trees.
7. The Botanic Garden _____ (suggests, suggest) a tour of 45 – 75 minutes for the Lightscape.

5. Exercise 5 (Rule 10). Choose the correct verb. The first one is an example.

1. Besides doing interesting outdoor activities, people in Chicago also (enjoys, enjoy) many indoor comforts. → enjoy
2. Many people (does, do) not know that there (is, are) 250 theaters and 5 Tony Award winning theater companies in Chicago.
3. The Chicago Theater District in different downtown areas (has, have) over 100 years of history.
4. Arie Crown Theater at the McCormick Place (has, have) the largest capacity, 4000+ seats.
5. One of the most famous theaters (is, are) Goodman Theatre. It (is, are) also the oldest and largest not-for-profit theatre.
6. During the winter, many classic shows such as "It's a Wonderful Life" and "A Christmas Carol" (attracts, attract) people from far and near.
7. All the theater lovers in Chicago (is, are) lucky to have so many theatric attractions nearby.

6. Exercises 6, 7 and 8 (review). In the lesson material, correct the agreement errors in "Visiting Chicago Museums in Winter" (the book says seven), "Winter Fun at Home" (six) and "Winter Dining in Chicago" (ten), not counting the examples. Find each subject first.

More items: lesson material, the Pretest. Your tutor can check it.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me ten sentences, one for each of the ten rules, each with an agreement error. I will correct them and name the rule."
- "Ask me five questions about winter in my country. Correct every verb in my answers that does not agree with its subject."
- "Check my answers to the Pretest in the lesson material."
- "Here are my two paragraphs for Exercise 9: [paste]. List my agreement errors with the rule number for each."

Read aloud

Practise the -s ending of singular verbs. It sounds /s/, /z/ or /ɪz/.

1. The place welcomes /z/ over 100,000 skaters annually.
2. Each of our professors allows /z/ a few extra minutes for students to arrive at the classroom.
3. Neither of my two courses counts /s/ attendance as part of the grade.
4. The news about the Lightscape usually appears /z/ in the social media months ahead of time.
5. If that collective noun focuses /ɪz/ on its individual parts, it becomes "they".
6. The Botanic Garden suggests /s/ a tour of 45 – 75 minutes for the Lightscape.

Writing task

Exercise 9. Choose two of the topics and write a paragraph (about 8 to 10 sentences) on each. Pay attention to the subject-verb agreement.

1. What are different ways you have fun in winter?
2. What are popular places in your native country where people like to spend the winter?
3. What safe winter driving tips would you like to share?
4. What are different ways children enjoy snow days?
5. Have you had a snow day? If so, what did you do?

If you have never had snow, choose topic 1 or 2. Use at least five of the ten rules, for example a compound subject, "each of", "there is/are", a gerund subject and a prepositional phrase after the subject.

Self-editing checklist:

- Underline the subject of every verb; cross out prepositional phrases between them.
- Turn difficult subjects into he, she, it or they.
- Everyone, each of, one of and none of take a singular verb; people and police take a plural verb.
- After "there is/are", look at the noun that follows; with "or" and "nor", look at the part after them.
- Gerund and infinitive subjects take a singular verb.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1. Exercise 1 (book): 1 is; 2 welcomes; 3 is; 4 are; 5 have; 6 add.

2. Exercise 2 (book): 1 is; 2 likes; 3 draws, is; 4 is, reflects; 5 end.

3. Exercise 3 (book): 2 runs, are; 3 are; 4 is, seems; 5 offers; 6 is; 7 is.

4. Exercise 4 (book): 2 appears; 3 starts, ends; 4 are, is; 5 are; 6 enjoy, walk, listen; 7 suggests.

5. Exercise 5 (book): 2 do, are; 3 has; 4 has; 5 is, is; 6 attract; 7 are.

6. Exercises 6-8. The book gives no key.

- Exercise 6 (this guide finds six errors, not seven): There is more than sixty → There **are** more than sixty; There are always something → There **is** always something; the Field Museum have → **has**; it have a special exhibit → it **has**; started in 1942 ... but have expanded → **has** expanded; The trees represents → The trees **represent**.
- Exercise 7: A bag of popcorn and a cup of hot chocolate adds → **add** (Rule 2); The older child vacuum → **vacuums**; the younger child dust → **dusts**; there is many fitness programs → there **are**; what he or she like → **likes**; It depend → It **depends**.
- Exercise 8: Everyone are → **is**; Young people loves → **love**; Watching a play ... or visiting Sue in the Field Museum guarantee → **guarantees** (Rule 3: the part after "or" is a gerund, Rule 7); there are outdoor dining → there **is**; One of the restaurants are → **is**; It offer → **offers**; Each greenhouse hold → **holds**; ... and have a dinning time limit → **has**; Neither the food nor the drinks is → **are**; If anyone are → **is**. ("Dinning" is also a spelling mistake for "dining". The sentence in quotation marks is a quote, so it is not changed.)

My notes